Lab 4 Report

Trajectory optimisation and drone racing

Author details to be completed

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Summary

Polynomial trajectory optimisation connects waypoint geometry to the continuous state references required for quadrotor flight. This laboratory derives the single-segment minimum-velocity solutions, counts the conditions for multi-segment minimum-snap trajectories, and implements a ROS trajectory follower for the official Unity racing course. With endpoint positions alone, the optimum is $P(t) = t$ and its cost is 1 for all three polynomial degrees considered. A prescribed terminal velocity changes the solution: the cubic reduces the quadratic cost from 4 to 17/8. In the recorded Unity run, the quadrotor approached all 12 gate centres in order while tracking a 91.08 s reference trajectory. The active-flight position error had a root-mean-square (RMS) value of 0.319 m, and the final position was 0.169 m from the last gate centre.

1 Lab introduction and team information

The task is to convert a sequence of gate poses into a smooth flight reference and track it through the official simulated course. The exercises combine two analytical deliverables with a drone-racing implementation[1]. This report follows that sequence: quadratic programming explains how endpoint constraints shape a polynomial; multi-segment analysis explains how adjacent pieces join; the flight experiment shows how the resulting reference interacts with a feedback controller.

The implemented system is shown in Figure 1. Gate positions and orientations are supplied by the course map. The trajectory generator produces desired states, and the controller from Lab 3 closes the loop through the TESSE bridge. Team names, student numbers, group information and individual contributions will be added after the author details are confirmed.

2 Individual work

2.1 Deliverable 1: single-segment trajectory optimisation

The objective is to minimise squared velocity on the normalised interval $[0, 1]$:

$$\min_P J(P) = \int_0^1 [P'(t)]^2 \, dt, \qquad P(0) = 0, \quad P(1) = 1. \tag{1}$$

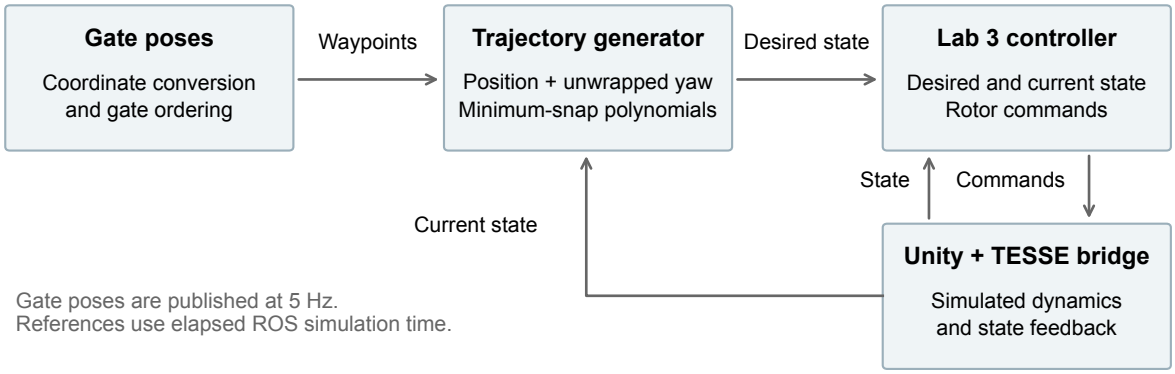


Figure 1: Implemented ROS control loop. Gate poses enter the generator on `/desired_traj_vertices`; the generator publishes `/desired_state`, and feedback arrives on `/current_state`. Arrows show command and feedback interfaces.

Write $P(t) = \sum_{i=1}^{N} p_i t^i$. The constant coefficient is zero because $P(0) = 0$. With $\boldsymbol{p} = [p_1, \ldots, p_N]^T$, direct integration gives

$$J = \boldsymbol{p}^T Q \boldsymbol{p}, \qquad Q_{ij} = \frac{ij}{i+j-1}, \qquad A\boldsymbol{p} = b, \quad A = [1, \ldots, 1], \quad b = 1. \tag{2}$$

Q is positive definite: a nonzero coefficient vector gives a nonzero derivative polynomial and hence a strictly positive integral of its square. Thus each feasible equality-constrained problem has a unique minimum. A solver that defines the objective as $\frac{1}{2}\boldsymbol{p}^T H \boldsymbol{p}$ must use $H = 2Q$.

2.1.1 Question 1: degree one

For $P(t) = p_1 t$, the endpoint equation fixes $p_1 = 1$. Therefore

$$\boxed{P^*(t) = t, \qquad J^* = 1.} \tag{3}$$

2.1.2 Question 2: degree two

For $P(t) = p_2 t^2 + p_1 t$, the requested matrices and objective are

$$Q = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 1 & 4/3 \end{bmatrix}, \quad A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 1 \end{bmatrix}, \quad b = 1, \qquad J = p_1^2 + 2p_1 p_2 + \frac{4}{3} p_2^2. \tag{4}$$

Substituting $p_1 = 1 - p_2$ gives $J = 1 + \frac{1}{3} p_2^2$. The optimum is $\boldsymbol{p}^* = (1, 0)^T$, so $P^*(t) = t$ and $J^* = 1$. The quadratic term provides no cost reduction for these boundary conditions.

2.1.3 Question 3: degree three and the Euler–Lagrange equation

For $P(t) = p_3 t^3 + p_2 t^2 + p_1 t$,

$$Q = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 1 & 1 \\ 1 & 4/3 & 3/2 \\ 1 & 3/2 & 9/5 \end{bmatrix}, \quad A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 1 & 1 \end{bmatrix}, \quad b = 1. \tag{5}$$

The Karush–Kuhn–Tucker (KKT) equations,

$$2Q\boldsymbol{p} + A^T\lambda = 0, \qquad A\boldsymbol{p} = b, \tag{6}$$

give $\boldsymbol{p}^* = (1, 0, 0)^T$ and $\lambda = -2$. Again $J^* = 1$. For the integrand $(P')^2$, the Euler–Lagrange equation is $P'' = 0$, which yields the same linear trajectory. Cauchy–Schwarz also gives the global bound

$$J \geq \left(\int_0^1 P'(t)\,dt\right)^2 = [P(1) - P(0)]^2 = 1. \tag{7}$$

Equality requires constant velocity, so increasing the degree cannot improve this result.

2.1.4 Question 4: prescribed terminal velocity

Adding $P'(1) = -2$ supplies a second constraint row, $[1, 2, \ldots, N]$, with $b = (1, -2)^T$. The equality-constrained minimum can be written as

$$\boldsymbol{p}^* = Q^{-1}A^T(AQ^{-1}A^T)^{-1}b. \tag{8}$$

For degree two,

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 1 & 2 \end{bmatrix}, \quad b = \begin{bmatrix} 1 \\ -2 \end{bmatrix}, \quad \boldsymbol{p}^* = \begin{bmatrix} 4 \\ -3 \end{bmatrix}. \tag{9}$$

Both coefficients are fixed by the constraints, giving

$$\boxed{P^*(t) = 4t - 3t^2, \qquad J^* = \int_0^1 (4 - 6t)^2\,dt = 4.} \tag{10}$$

For degree three,

$$A = \begin{bmatrix} 1 & 1 & 1 \\ 1 & 2 & 3 \end{bmatrix}, \qquad b = \begin{bmatrix} 1 \\ -2 \end{bmatrix}. \tag{11}$$

Set $p_3 = z$. The constraints give $p_1 = 4 + z$ and $p_2 = -3 - 2z$, so

$$J(z) = 4 + z + \frac{2}{15}z^2, \qquad J'(z) = 1 + \frac{4}{15}z. \tag{12}$$

Its minimum occurs at $z = -15/4$, with

$$\boxed{P^*(t) = \frac{1}{4}t + \frac{9}{2}t^2 - \frac{15}{4}t^3, \qquad J^* = \frac{17}{8}.} \tag{13}$$

The cubic satisfies both $P(1) = 1$ and $P'(1) = -2$. Its additional freedom reduces the integrated squared velocity by 46.875% relative to the quadratic. Both trajectories overshoot the final position before returning with negative velocity (Figure 2). These solutions minimise the cost within their specified polynomial spaces; the linear Euler–Lagrange solution cannot satisfy the added terminal-velocity condition.

Figure 3 shows the reduced objectives after the endpoint equations have been eliminated. The stationary points of these one-dimensional quadratics give the same coefficients as the matrix solution. In the terminal-velocity problem, setting the cubic coefficient to zero recovers the degree-two solution.

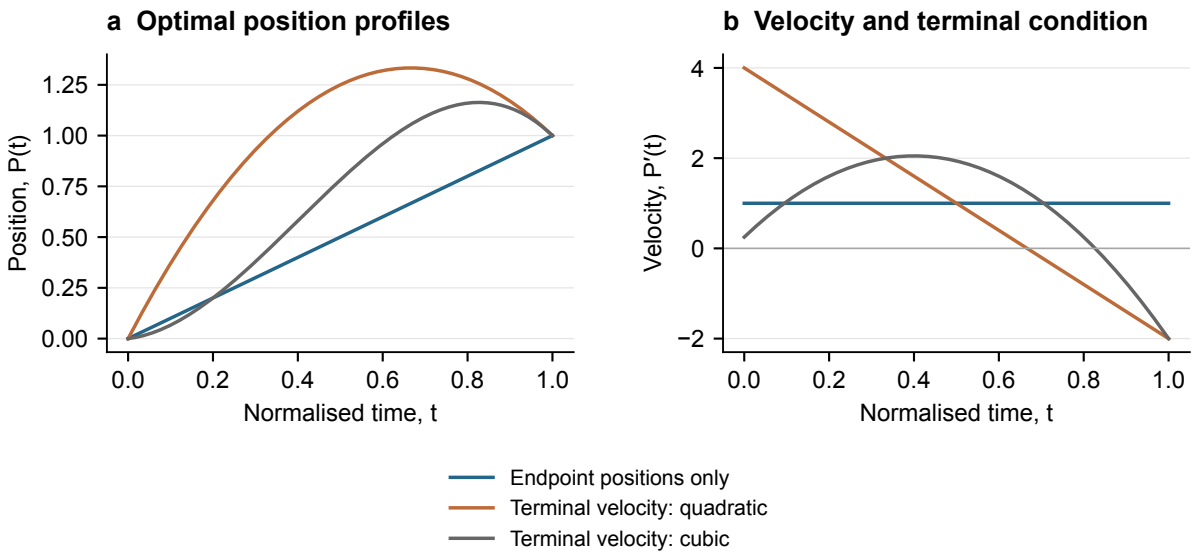


Figure 2: Exact solutions of the single-segment exercises. (a) Position profiles. (b) Their analytic derivatives. The blue line solves the position-only problem for degrees one, two and three. The other curves include $P'(1) = -2$; their costs are 4 (quadratic) and 17/8 (cubic). These are analytical curves, not flight measurements.

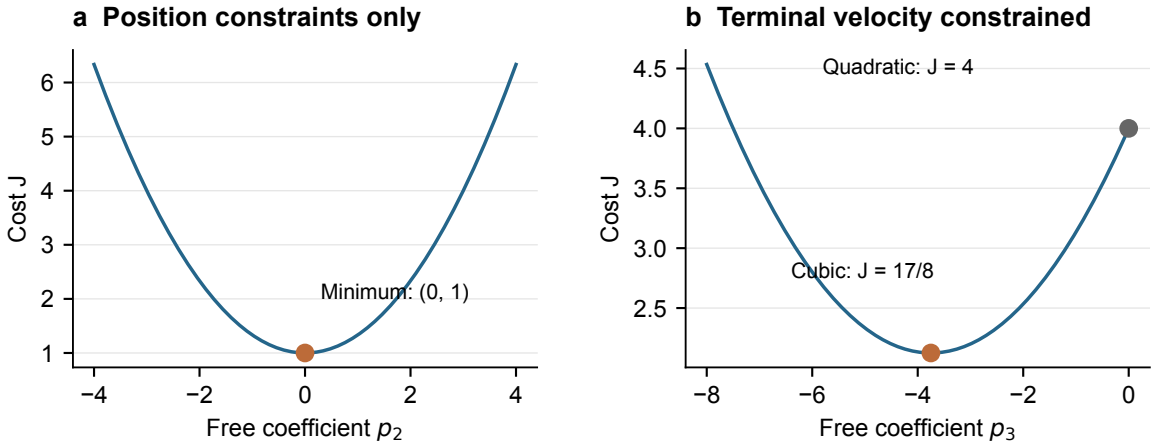


Figure 3: The analytical cost landscapes. (a) For the position-only quadratic, $J = 1 + p_2^2/3$ is minimised at $p_2 = 0$. (b) With terminal velocity -2, the cubic's reduced objective is $J = 4 + p_3 + 2p_3^2/15$. Its minimum at $p_3 = -15/4$ has cost 17/8; the point $p_3 = 0$ has the quadratic cost 4.

2.2 Deliverable 2: multi-segment trajectory optimisation

All counts below refer to one scalar coordinate, prescribed waypoint positions and fixed, strictly increasing knot times $t_0 < \cdots < t_k$. Coordinates can be treated independently when the cost is their summed squared derivative norm.

2.2.1 Question 1: minimum snap

For k segments, the snap objective is

$$J = \sum_{i=1}^{k} \int_{t_{i-1}}^{t_i} [P_i^{(4)}(t)]^2 \, dt. \tag{14}$$

Euler–Lagrange gives $P_i^{(8)} = 0$ on every open segment. Each piece therefore has degree at most seven and eight coefficients, giving $8k$ unknowns. Assume that position, velocity, acceleration and jerk are fixed at the overall start and end. The conditions determining the stationary optimum are listed in Table 1.

Table 1: Scalar condition count for k minimum-snap segments. The free-derivative row combines continuity constraints with natural optimality conditions.

Type	Conditions	Count
Waypoint	Fix both ends of each piece to the appropriate waypoint.	$2k$
Free derivative	Match derivatives of orders 1 to 6 across each interior knot.	$6(k-1)$
Fixed derivative	Specify orders 1 to 3 at the overall start and end.	6
Total	Eight conditions per polynomial piece.	$8k$

There are $k+1$ physical waypoints. Each interior waypoint supplies two position equations, one for each adjacent piece, while each overall endpoint supplies one. For $k = 3$, the counts are 6 waypoint, 12 free-derivative and 6 fixed-derivative equations, totalling 24.

The derivative map in Figure 4 shows where these conditions act. Each interior position is imposed on both adjacent pieces, whereas the free derivatives share a common value across the knot.

Velocity, acceleration and jerk continuity define admissible trajectories. Their common values at interior knots remain free. Minimising snap then supplies continuity of derivatives four, five and six as natural optimality conditions. The seventh derivative may jump because the interior positions are prescribed. Thus a QP needs $2k + 3(k-1) + 6 = 5k + 3$ explicit equality constraints; optimisation supplies the remaining $3(k-1)$ conditions. Treating all $8k$ equations as prescribed derivative values would remove the distinction between feasibility and optimality.

2.2.2 Question 2: a general derivative order

For an objective involving the squared rth derivative,

$$J = \sum_{i=1}^{k} \int_{t_{i-1}}^{t_i} [P_i^{(r)}(t)]^2 \, dt, \tag{15}$$

Euler–Lagrange gives $P_i^{(2r)} = 0$. The degree is at most $2r-1$, with $2rk$ coefficients in total. Prescribe endpoint derivatives of orders $1, \ldots, r-1$. The counts become

$$\underbrace{2k}_{\text{waypoint}} + \underbrace{(2r-2)(k-1)}_{\text{free derivative}} + \underbrace{2(r-1)}_{\text{fixed derivative}} = 2rk. \tag{16}$$

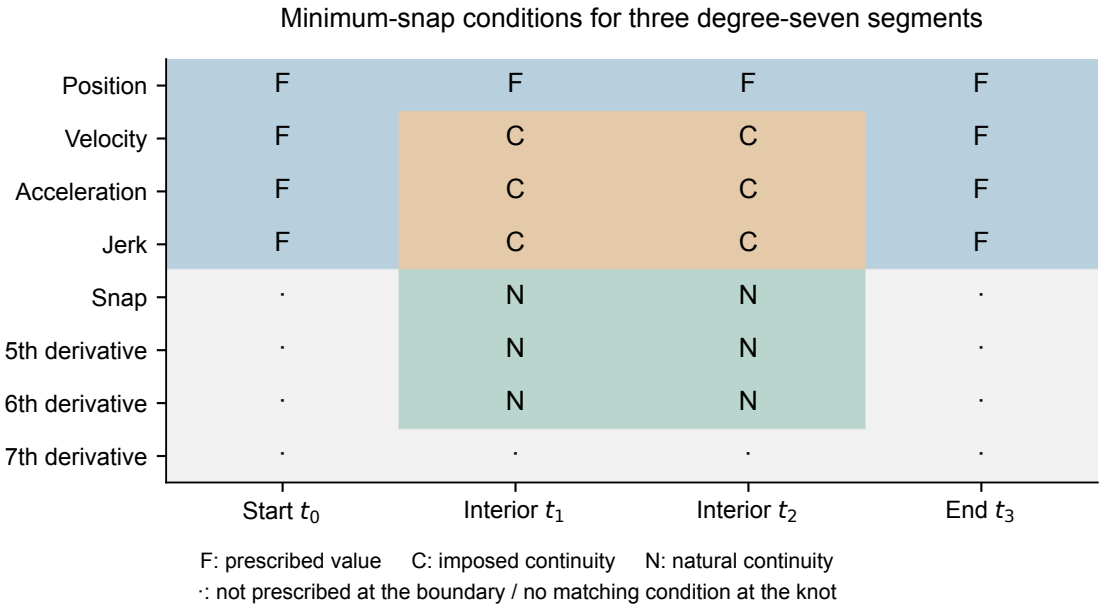


Figure 4: Condition map for the theoretical three-segment minimum-snap problem. F denotes a prescribed value, C an explicit continuity constraint and N a natural continuity condition supplied by stationarity. Each interior F in the position row represents two scalar equations. Dots identify derivative values that are not prescribed at an endpoint, or derivatives with no knot-matching condition.

The free-derivative equations match orders $1, \ldots, 2r-2$ at each interior knot. Orders $1, \ldots, r-1$ are continuity constraints; orders $r, \ldots, 2r-2$ follow from stationarity. The explicit QP has $(r+1)k + r - 1$ equality constraints and $(r-1)(k-1)$ free directions.

To obtain the natural conditions, integrate the first variation by parts r times:

$$\frac{1}{2}\delta J_i = \left[\sum_{j=0}^{r-1}(-1)^j P_i^{(r+j)}\delta P_i^{(r-1-j)}\right]_{t_{i-1}}^{t_i} + (-1)^r \int_{t_{i-1}}^{t_i} P_i^{(2r)}\delta P_i \, dt. \tag{17}$$

At an interior waypoint, $\delta P = 0$. The remaining common variations $\delta P^{(1)}, \ldots, \delta P^{(r-1)}$ are arbitrary, so their boundary terms require continuity of orders $r, \ldots, 2r-2$. The count also covers $k = 1$ and $r = 1$: the corresponding interior or derivative conditions disappear.

3 Team work

3.1 Deliverable 3: trajectory generation and following

The implementation uses the provided polynomial optimisation library[2] and completes Part 0 and Parts 1.1–1.3 of the exercise. The course contains 12 ordered gate poses. The position conversion from Unity coordinates to the ROS world frame is

$$(x_R, y_R, z_R) = (x_U, z_U, y_U). \tag{18}$$

For quaternion components ordered as (x, y, z, w), the corresponding conversion is $(q_{Rx}, q_{Ry}, q_{Rz}, q_{Rw}) = (-q_{Ux}, -q_{Uz}, -q_{Uy}, q_{Uw})$. The waypoint publisher sorts gates by their numerical index and publishes a `PoseArray` at 5 Hz.

Figure 5 displays the ordered centres and their yaw directions after this conversion. The dotted centre-to-centre line shows the order of the waypoints; the optimiser determines the smooth path between them.

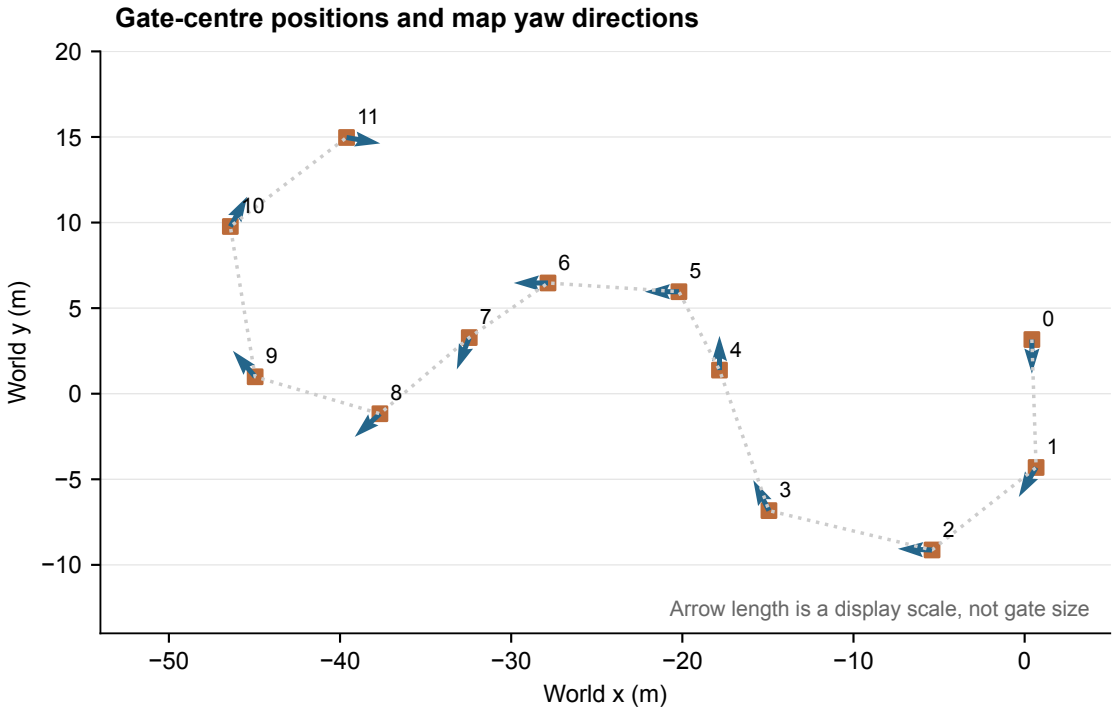


Figure 5: Course waypoint geometry in the ROS world frame. Squares denote the 12 gate centres; arrows show the horizontal yaw directions extracted from the converted quaternions. All arrows use the same display length. They do not encode gate dimensions, and the dotted line is a waypoint-order guide.

3.1.1 Part 0: first-gate reference

The simple planner takes the first gate pose, normalises its quaternion and publishes a desired state with zero linear and angular velocity and acceleration. A 0.01 s timer keeps the command active and broadcasts the desired pose in the world frame. Empty lists and invalid first poses are rejected. The saved hover record contains the position $(0.423, 3.165, 2.374)$ m; this individual sample is not used to estimate a settling time or a steady-state error statistic.

3.1.2 Part 1.1: initialise from the current state

The follower obtains position and yaw from `/current_state` and waits for a valid state before planning. Waypoints received first are retained until that state arrives. The initial vertex is the measured position, which joins the current vehicle location to the first gate.

Once a trajectory exists, repeated waypoint messages do not restart it.

3.1.3 Part 1.2: optimise position and yaw

The generator builds a three-dimensional position trajectory and a scalar yaw trajectory using identical segment durations. Interior vertices constrain the gate position and yaw. Successive yaw angles are unwrapped using

$$\psi_i = \psi_{i-1} + \operatorname{atan2}\Big(\sin(\bar{\psi}_i - \psi_{i-1}), \cos(\bar{\psi}_i - \psi_{i-1})\Big), \tag{19}$$

where $\bar{\psi}_i$ is the yaw extracted from the gate quaternion. This selects the short angular increment across the $\pm\pi$ boundary.

Both optimisers minimise snap using ten coefficients per segment, so their polynomials have degree at most nine. The library shares endpoint derivatives through order four at interior vertices. Calls to `makeStartOrEnd(..., SNAP)` set derivatives one through four to zero at the overall endpoints. This implementation therefore includes endpoint snap constraints and uses a different polynomial space from the minimal degree-seven derivation in Deliverable 2. The mathematical count there applies to the stated endpoint-through-jerk problem.

The segment-time estimator uses gate spacing with parameters $v_{\max} = 2\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-1}}$ and $a_{\max} = 1\,\mathrm{m\,s^{-2}}$. A time scale of 1 is applied and every segment is at least 0.5 s long. These parameters choose durations; the linear QP does not impose them as hard velocity or acceleration bounds.

3.1.4 Part 1.3: publish the desired state

The generator evaluates position, velocity, acceleration, yaw, yaw rate and yaw acceleration at the elapsed ROS time. The sample time is clipped to $[0, T]$, where T is the trajectory duration. The final rest reference therefore continues after T. The desired-state timer is configured at 100 Hz; the controller timer is configured at 200 Hz. These settings describe requested timer rates, not measured throughput of the simulator.

3.2 Experimental configuration and measurement

The recorded experiment used the official Lab 4 Unity 2019.3.9f1 simulator with Box64 0.3.6 on ARM64 and ROS Noetic. The selected controller gains were $k_x = 1.2$, $k_v = 2.0$, $k_R = 1.2$ and $k_\omega = 0.7$, with drag compensation disabled. State and desired-state timeout settings were both 1 s. The saved build log reports seven successfully built packages, and the saved integration checks cover input validation, initial-state waiting, repeated waypoint messages, yaw wrapping, derivative consistency and endpoint holding.

Results below use one recorded Unity run. The telemetry contains 6,064 rows; each row pairs a current-state position with the latest received desired-state position. This is the recorded online pairing, without subsequent temporal interpolation. For sample j, the Euclidean tracking error is

$$e_j = \|\boldsymbol{x}_j - \boldsymbol{x}_{d,j}\|_2, \qquad e_{\mathrm{RMS}} = \sqrt{\frac{1}{n}\sum_{j\in\mathcal{A}} e_j^2}, \tag{20}$$

where $\mathcal{A}$ contains the 4,556 samples whose reference time is below $T - 0.01\,\mathrm{s}$ and $n = |\mathcal{A}|$. The remaining 1,508 samples cover the terminal reference hold. This distinction keeps the active-flight metric separate from the terminal behaviour. All samples are retained in the time-series figures.

For gate i, the closest recorded centre distance and its time are

$$d_i = \min_j \|\boldsymbol{x}_j - \boldsymbol{g}_i\|_2, \qquad t_i^{\mathrm{near}} = t_{\arg\min_j \|\boldsymbol{x}_j - \boldsymbol{g}_i\|_2}. \tag{21}$$

Here $\boldsymbol{g}_i$ is the gate centre in ROS world coordinates. These are closest-approach times in the complete recording, including the final hold. The statistics describe 6,064 time samples within one run.

3.3 Recorded flight through the course

The trajectory and measured flight follow the sequence of all 12 gate centres (Figure 6). The reference lasts 91.0797 s, while the full telemetry record spans 121.30 s. The terminal reference is first recorded at 91.16 s on the telemetry clock and remains active for the remaining 30.14 s.

The spatial view in Figure 7 makes the vertical excursions visible along the course. Figure 8 then separates the recorded and desired coordinates so that changes in altitude can be compared with the horizontal motion.

Table 2: Measurements from the single recorded Unity run. Tracking statistics use active-flight samples; final position error uses the last sample.

Quantity	Value
Reference trajectory duration	91.0797 s
Total telemetry duration	121.30 s
Active-flight RMS position error	0.319 m
Active-flight maximum position error	0.578 m
Largest closest-approach distance among the gates	0.448 m
Final position error relative to the last gate centre	0.169 m
Terminal-hold minimum / maximum position error	0.151 / 0.585 m

3.4 Tracking error and gate-centre visits

The active-flight RMS error was 0.319 m, with a maximum of 0.578 m. Figure 9 shows the complete error trace and the closest distance to every gate. The closest-approach times increase strictly with gate index (Table 3), and each closest distance is below 0.45 m. This 0.45 m value describes the observed distances; it is not a course-defined acceptance threshold. Gates 4 and 5 have the largest closest distances, 0.445 and 0.448 m.

The signed residuals in Figure 10 isolate the direction of the tracking error. Their active-flight RMS values are 0.077 m in X, 0.065 m in Y and 0.303 m in Z. The vertical component therefore makes the largest contribution to the position error in this run. Figure 11 summarises the sample distribution: the active-flight median is 0.285 m and the 95th percentile is 0.507 m. These are descriptive statistics of the recorded time samples.

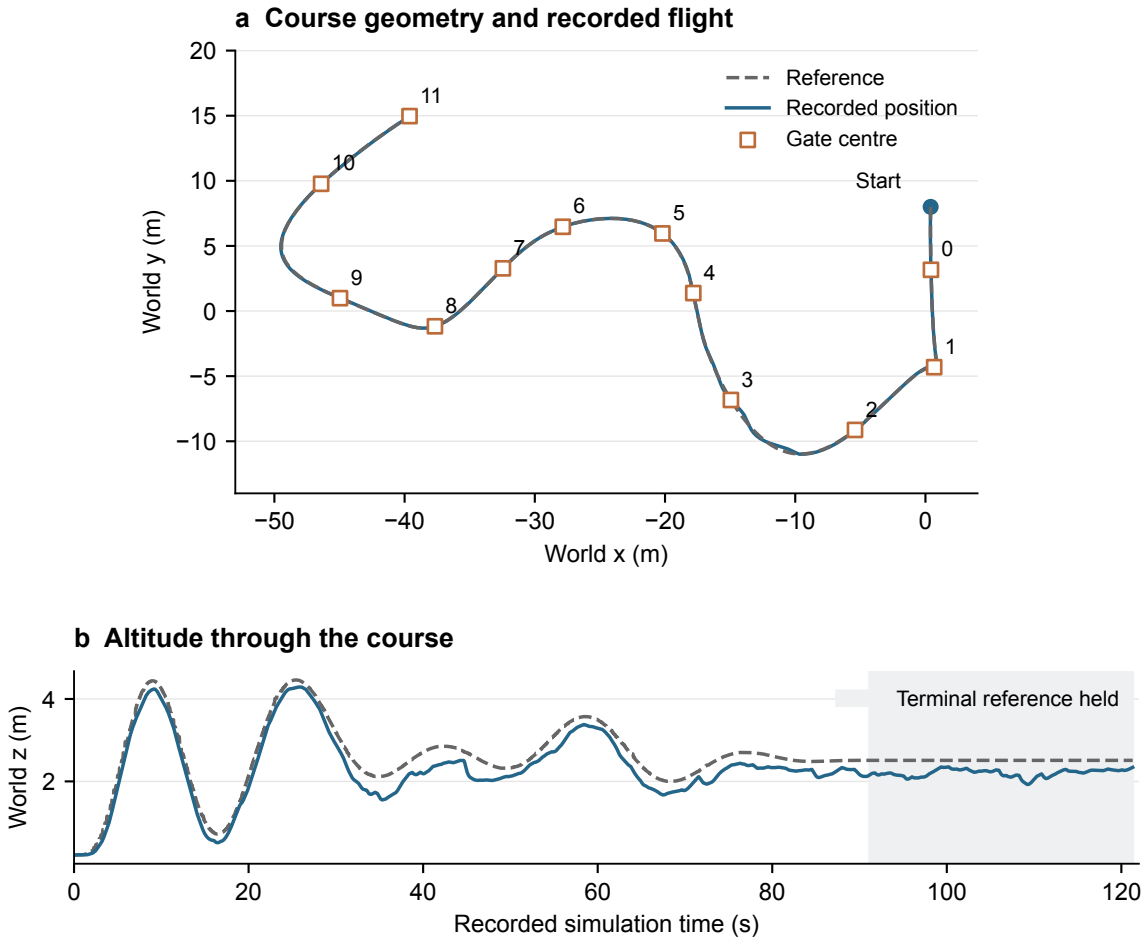


Figure 6: Official Unity flight from the recorded telemetry. (a) Horizontal projection of the reference and measured trajectory, with gate indices 0–11. (b) Reference and measured altitude over the full recording. The shaded region marks the terminal reference hold. All 6,064 samples are plotted; equal scaling of the horizontal axes preserves course geometry.

Table 3: Closest-approach times and distances. Gate numbering follows the course map. The final gate's closest approach occurs during the terminal hold.

Gate	Time (s)	Distance (m)	Gate	Time (s)	Distance (m)
0	5.72	0.200	6	52.94	0.201
1	13.02	0.100	7	58.82	0.220
2	21.18	0.276	8	65.86	0.360
3	30.82	0.268	9	73.64	0.405
4	39.66	0.445	10	82.46	0.252
5	44.88	0.448	11	100.18	0.151

3.5 Recorded attitude and terminal response

Figure 12 adds the attitude history from the recorded quaternions. After normalisation, each quaternion is converted to roll, pitch and yaw using the ZYX Euler-angle convention. Yaw is unwrapped in time to keep the displayed heading continuous across the angular representation boundary. The plot reports the measured attitude; the CSV does not contain a desired-attitude series for an attitude-error comparison.

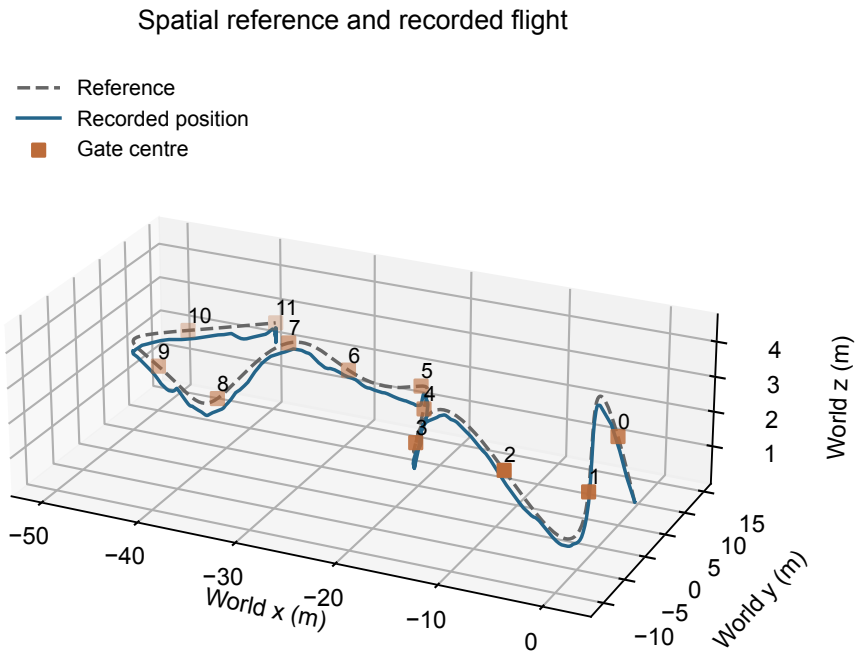


Figure 7: Three-dimensional view of the recorded and reference trajectories, with gate centres labelled 0–11. All telemetry samples are included. The vertical display scale is enlarged relative to the horizontal axes to reveal changes in altitude; tick labels retain physical distances in metres.

Figure 13 enlarges the terminal interval. Time is reset to zero at the first telemetry row classified as terminal hold. The altitude trace shows the vertical response against the fixed final reference while the upper panel retains the full Euclidean position error.
The last position was 0.169 m from the final gate centre. Over the terminal hold, the error ranged from 0.151 to 0.585 m, so the final sample satisfies the offline 0.20 m tolerance without establishing that the entire hold stayed inside it. The original live-monitor log ended with a failed completion check; the accompanying run notes identify its threshold as 0.08 m. The later offline check uses 0.20 m. Reporting the trace and final distance preserves the measured outcome independently of either threshold.

3.6 Simulator view and terminal behaviour

The retained simulator screenshot in Figure 14 places the telemetry in its visual context. It shows the quadrotor near a green gate with additional gates visible along the course. The saved screen recording and rosbag accompany this report locally. The bag metadata records 6,284 current-state messages and 3,125 desired-state messages over approximately 125 s; its recording starts before the paired telemetry series, so the durations and sample counts differ.

Figures 15 and 16 sample the saved video at 10 s playback intervals, starting at 5 s. They show the progression of the rendered course and the later views near the terminal gate. Their labels refer to video playback time, which has not been synchronised with the telemetry clock. Frames retain their full area in chronological order.

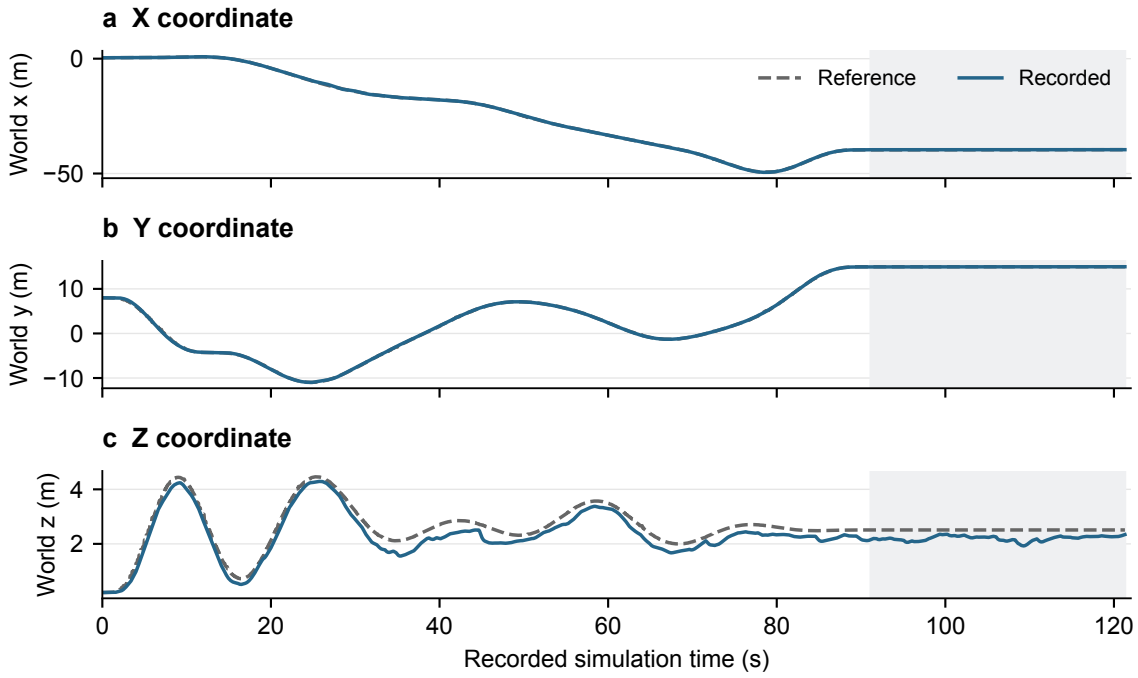


Figure 8: Coordinate-wise reference tracking through the complete recording. The panels show world X, Y and Z positions, respectively. Dashed lines are references, solid lines are recorded positions, and shading marks the terminal hold. The panels use different position ranges, as labelled on their axes.

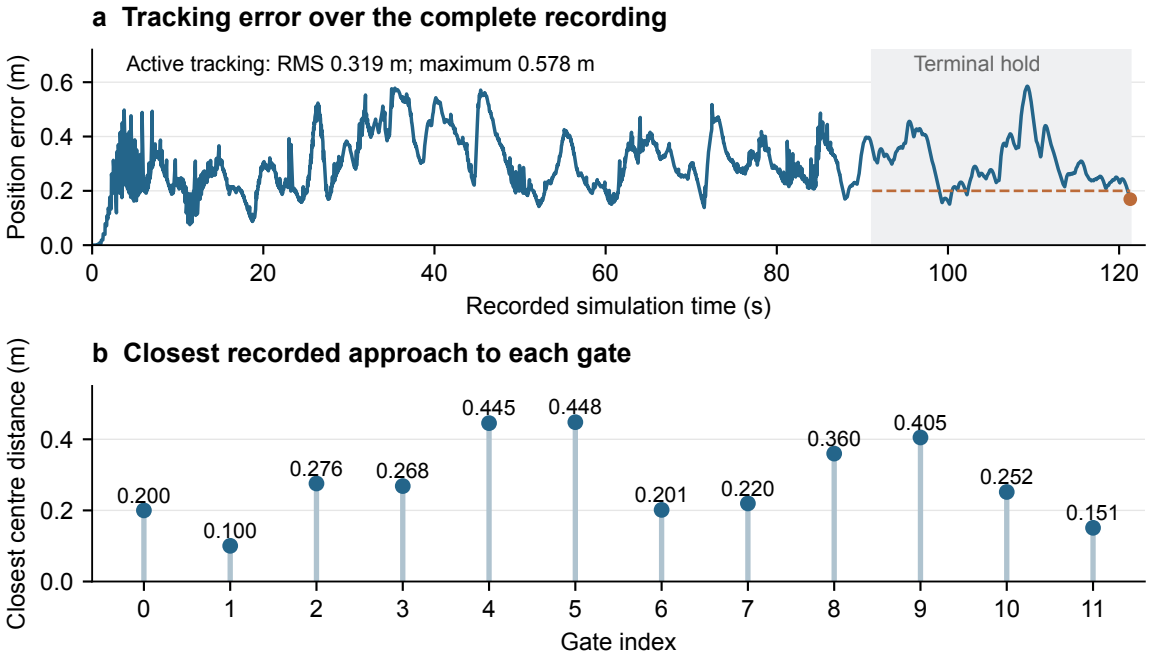


Figure 9: Tracking accuracy and gate-centre proximity. (a) Euclidean error for all recorded samples. The shaded interval is the terminal hold; the dashed 0.20 m line is the local offline terminal tolerance, and the orange point is the last sample. (b) Minimum Euclidean distance to each gate centre over the complete recording. All measurements are from one Unity flight.

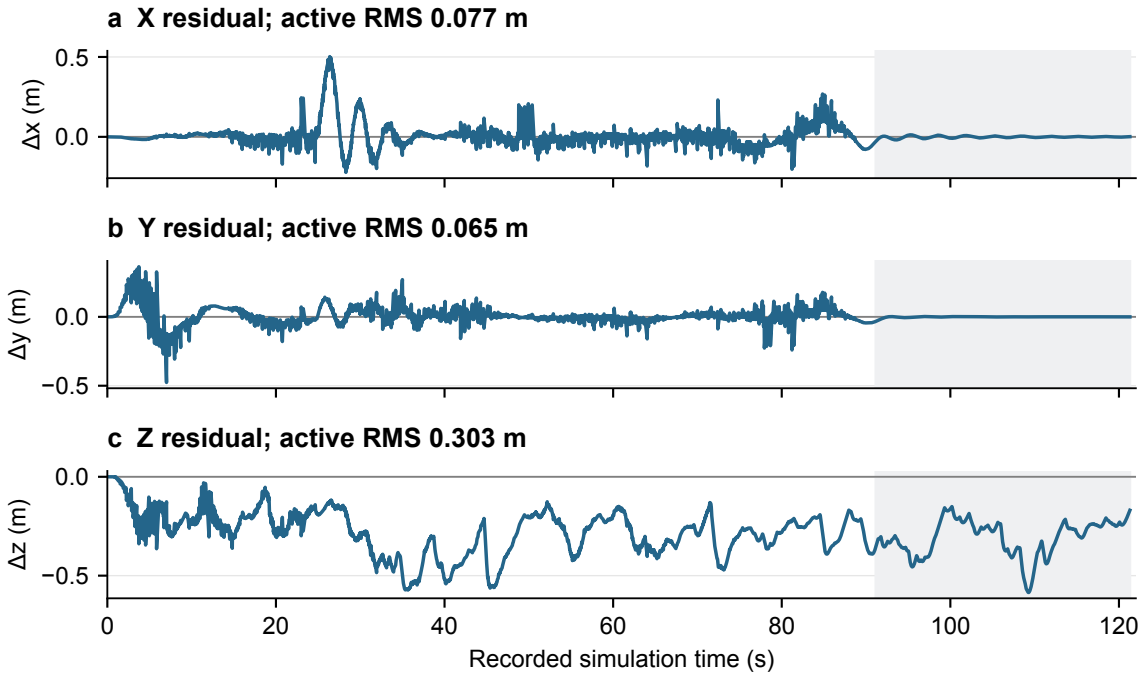


Figure 10: Signed coordinate residuals, defined as recorded minus reference position. Panel titles give the RMS over the 4,556 active-flight samples. All 6,064 samples appear in the traces; shaded intervals mark the terminal hold. Individual axes use separate vertical ranges to expose each component.

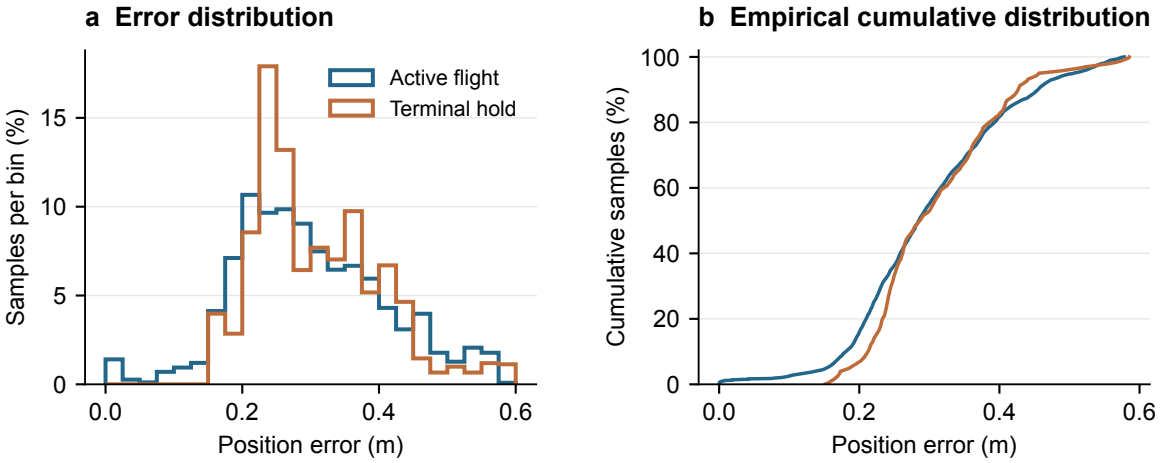


Figure 11: Distribution of Euclidean tracking error. (a) Histograms with 0.025 m bins, each normalised by the number of samples in its own phase. (b) Empirical cumulative distributions using every sample in each phase. The active and terminal phases contain 4,556 and 1,508 observations, respectively, from the same flight.

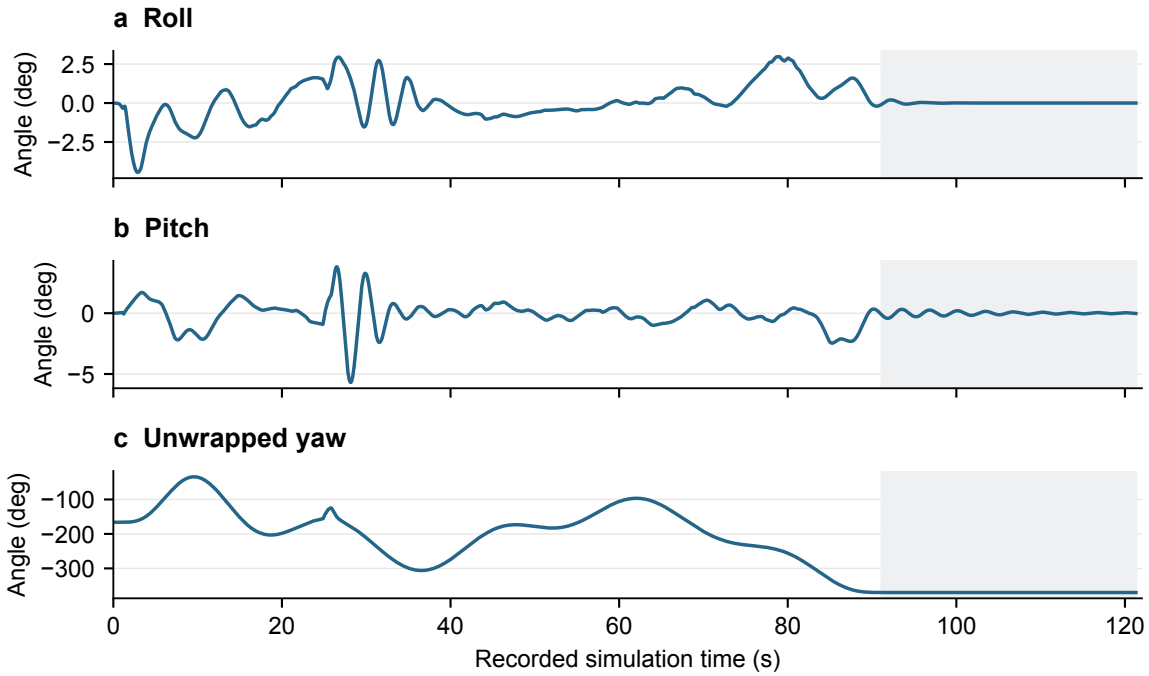


Figure 12: Recorded roll, pitch and unwrapped yaw in degrees. Angles are derived from all 6,064 recorded quaternions, using the normalised (x, y, z, w) components and a ZYX convention. Yaw can extend outside $[-180, 180]$ degrees after unwrapping. The shaded interval marks the terminal reference hold.

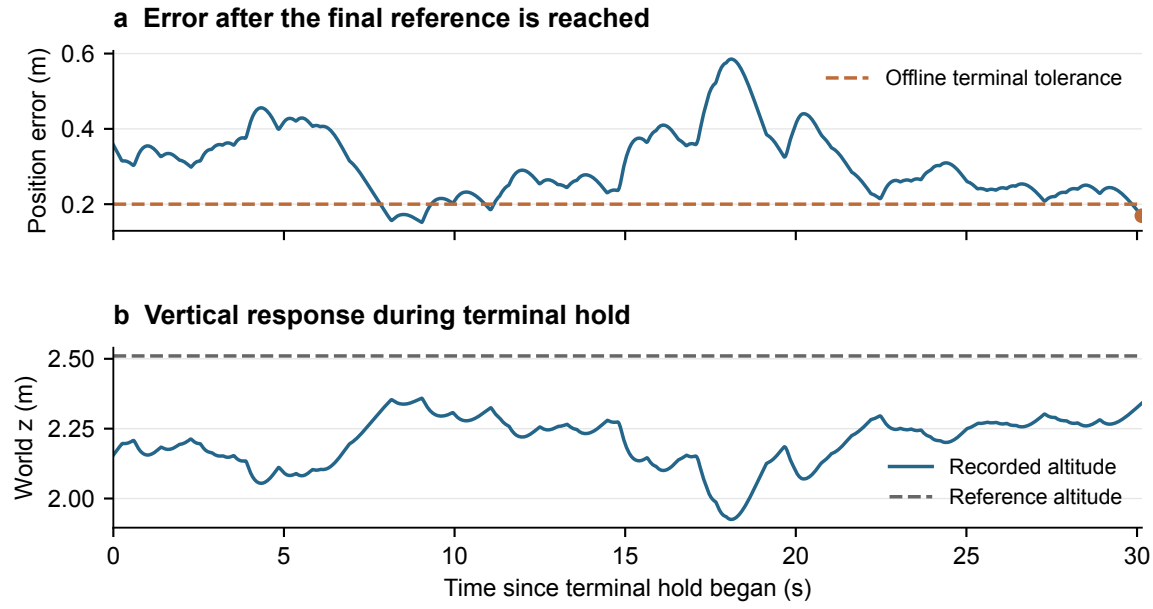


Figure 13: Detailed terminal response over all 1,508 hold samples. (a) Position error relative to the held reference; the dashed line is the offline 0.20 m terminal tolerance and the point marks the final sample. (b) Actual and reference altitude. The time axis begins at recorded simulation time 91.16 s.

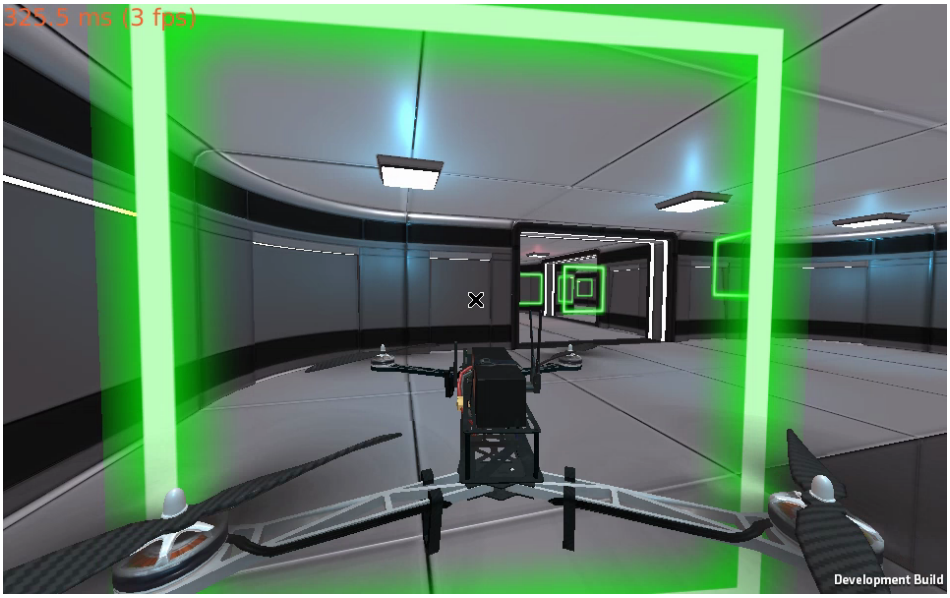


Figure 14: Retained view from the official Unity experiment. The screenshot is reproduced in full, with its original colours and aspect ratio. It supplies scene context for the trajectory plots; the gate-centre distances come from telemetry.

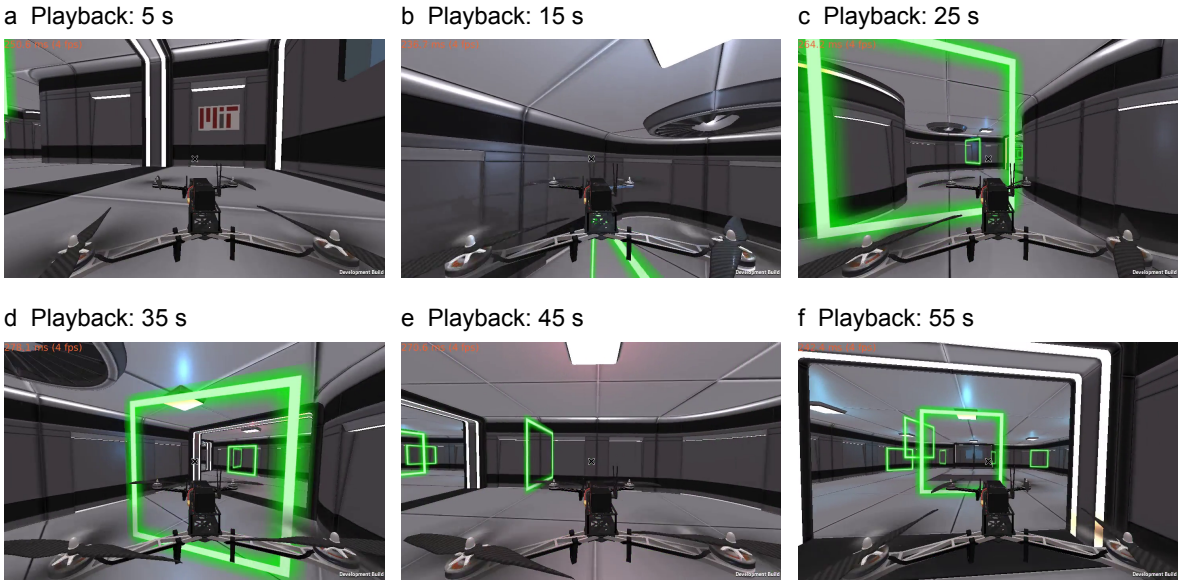


Figure 15: First six sampled views from the official Unity screen recording, at requested playback times 5, 15, 25, 35, 45 and 55 s. Each panel is a decoded 960×600 frame, scaled without cropping or colour adjustment. These playback times are distinct from the simulation timestamps on the data plots.

Appendix A provides a visual record for every gate, with complete centre-distance histories and local trajectory projections around the closest recorded approach.

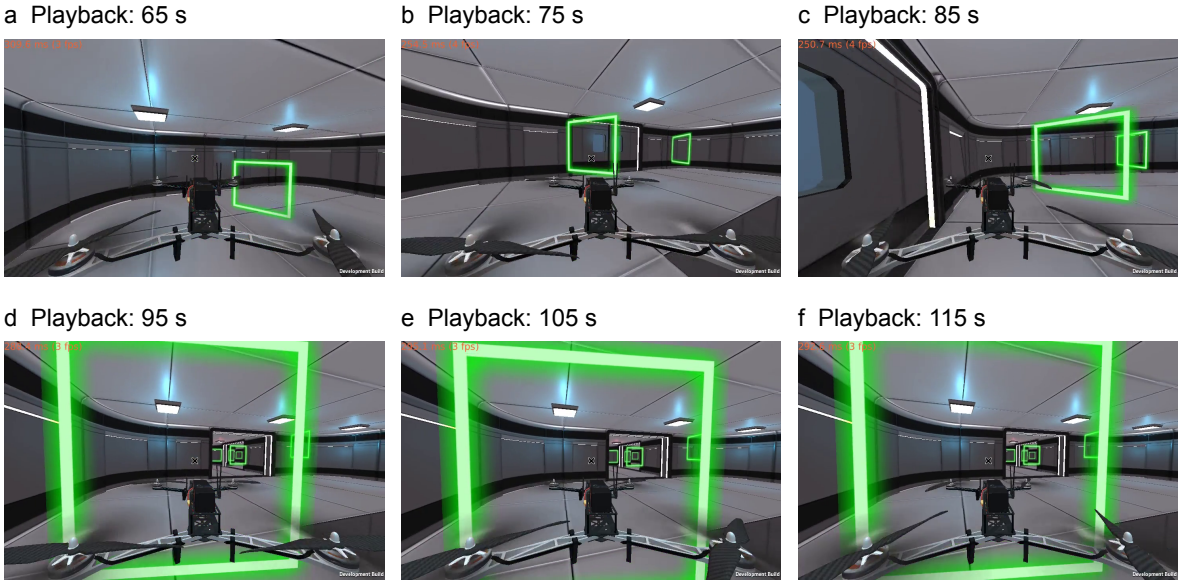


Figure 16: Later sampled views from the same recording, at requested playback times 65, 75, 85, 95, 105 and 115 s. Panels retain their original framing and colours. The final views document the scene near the terminal gate; no gate-event timestamps are inferred from this evenly spaced video sample.

4 Discussion

4.1 Polynomial freedom and boundary conditions

The single-segment solutions show when a higher polynomial degree is useful. With position constraints alone, constant velocity already reaches the global lower bound. The terminal-velocity condition changes the feasible set: a cubic can redistribute velocity over the interval and reduce the cost from 4 to 17/8. The overshoot in Figure 2 follows from arriving at the final point with negative velocity. Boundary conditions therefore determine the value of extra coefficients more directly than polynomial degree alone.

For multiple segments, the distinction between explicit constraints and natural conditions explains how the optimiser chooses free waypoint derivatives. In the flight implementation, shared position and yaw segment times keep the reference components synchronised, while angle unwrapping avoids a full-turn interpolation at a representation discontinuity. Endpoint sampling then gives the controller a persistent rest reference after the planned motion ends.

4.2 What the flight measurements establish

The recorded run supports ordered gate-centre visits and quantifies tracking over the course. Centre proximity is a spatial diagnostic: a collision-free crossing of every gate would require crossing geometry or simulator event records in addition to these distances. Likewise, 91.08 s is the reference duration, not an independently measured official race time. The optional speed challenge is outside the demonstrated result.

The terminal trace shows continued position variation after the reference stops. A time-window settling criterion would be needed to quantify sustained hover accuracy. No

controller comparison is available to attribute that variation to a particular gain, bridge timing effect or simulator model. The present results therefore describe the selected configuration and recorded run. They provide a concrete starting point for any subsequent time-allocation or gain study.

5 Conclusions

The analytical exercises connect polynomial coefficients to boundary conditions and identify the continuity and stationarity conditions for multi-segment planning. The implemented ROS follower extends that formulation to spatial waypoints and unwrapped yaw, then supplies the derivatives needed by the Lab 3 controller. In the official Unity recording, the vehicle approached all 12 gate centres in order with an active-flight RMS position error of 0.319 m. Together, the derivations and recorded flight demonstrate the complete chain from waypoint constraints to a tracked reference trajectory.

References

[1] MIT Visual Navigation for Autonomous Vehicles. *Lab 4: Exercises*, 2023 course materials. `https://vnav.mit.edu/labs_2023/lab4/exercises.html`. Accessed 10 October 2026.

[2] ETH Zurich Autonomous Systems Lab. *mav_trajectory_generation: Polynomial trajectory generation and optimisation.* `https://github.com/ethz-asl/mav_trajectory_generation`. Library documentation and the implementation distributed with the laboratory. Accessed 10 October 2026.

A Per-gate trajectory views

Figures 17 and 18 retain the complete time history of distance to each of the 12 centres. The minima progress in gate order. Figures 19 and 20 show the local geometry within two seconds before and after each minimum, giving 201 samples per gate. Every gate is included with the same time-window rule and plotting scale.

A.1 Local trajectory projections

For the local views, $s = \cos\psi_i(x - x_i) + \sin\psi_i(y - y_i)$ is the horizontal offset projected along the map yaw of gate i, and the vertical coordinate is $z - z_i$. The square is the gate centre. The perpendicular horizontal coordinate is omitted from this two-dimensional projection, so the minimum distance in each title is still computed from the full three-dimensional position. These plots show local tracking geometry without assuming an unrecorded gate-opening size.

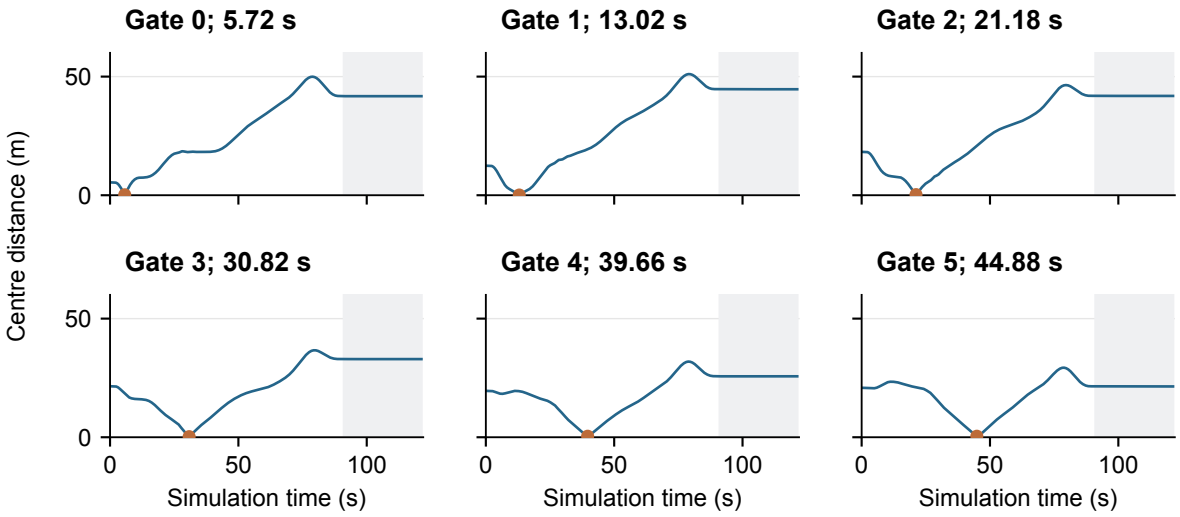


Figure 17: Complete centre-distance histories for gates 0–5. Each panel includes all 6,064 telemetry samples and uses the same axes. Orange points mark the global minimum for each gate; shading marks the terminal reference hold.

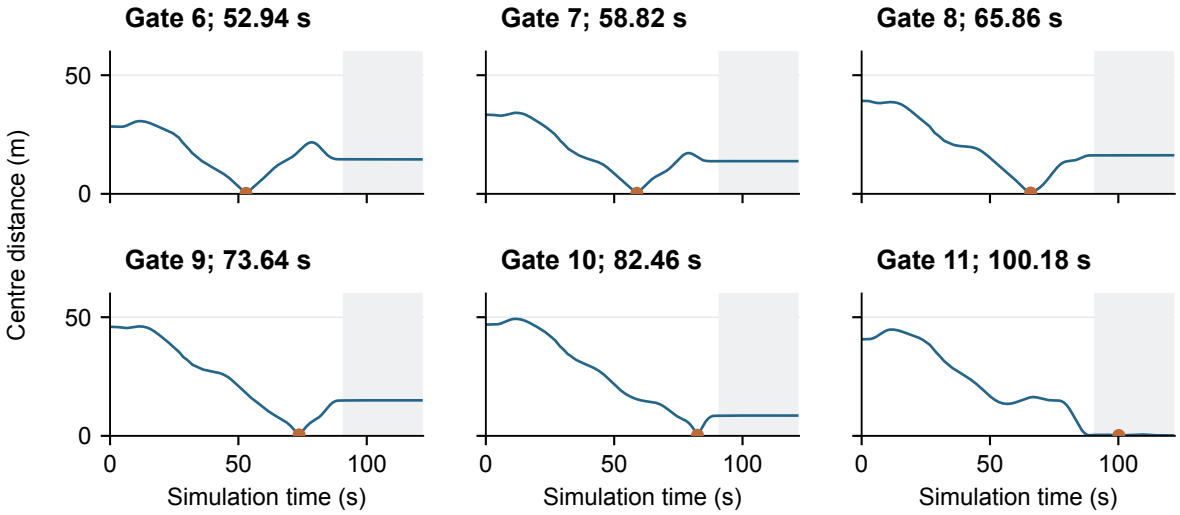


Figure 18: Complete centre-distance histories for gates 6–11, using the same sample set and scales as Figure 17. The last gate's global minimum occurs during the terminal hold.

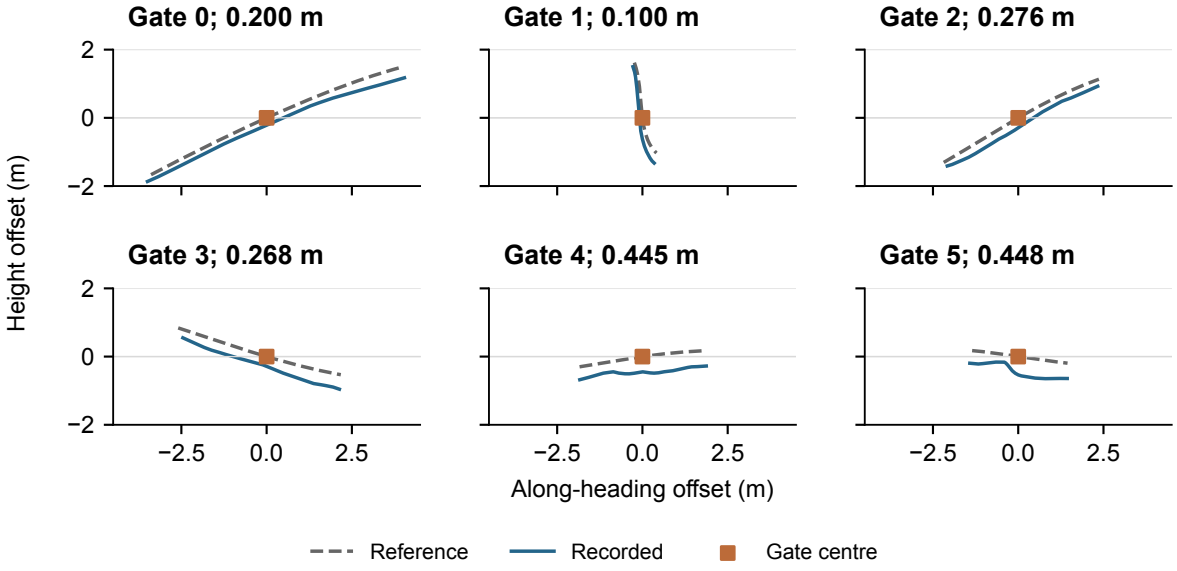


Figure 19: Local views around the closest approaches to gates 0–5. Each panel contains the 201 samples within ±2 s of that gate's minimum-distance time. Both axes show offsets in metres with equal scale; reference and recorded positions are projected onto along-heading offset and height. The square denotes the centre, and the title reports the minimum full 3D distance.

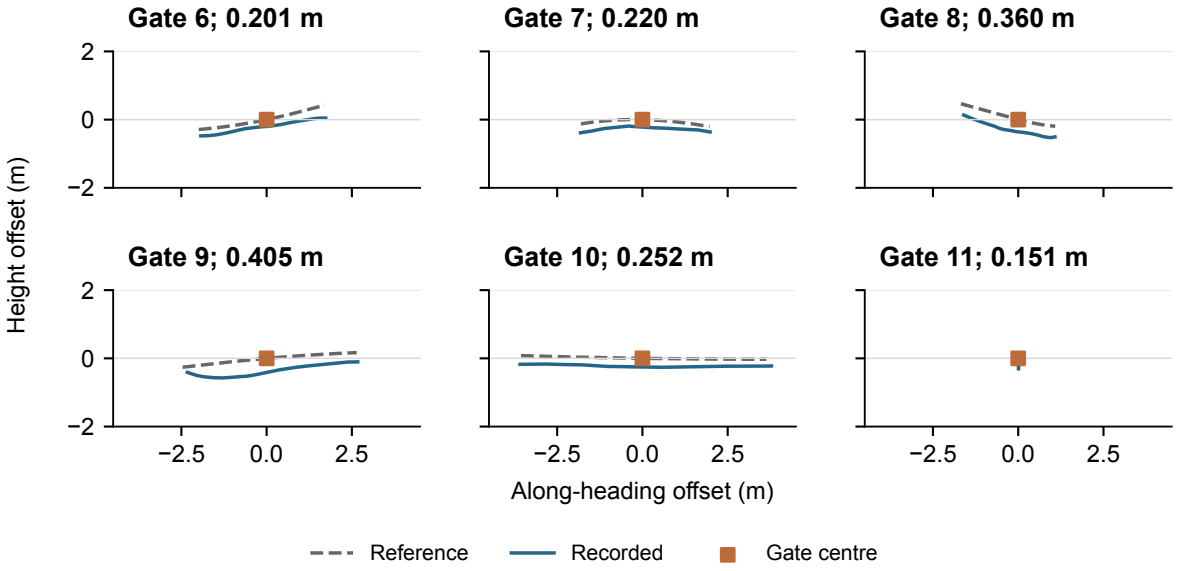


Figure 20: Local views for gates 6–11 using the same window and coordinate definitions as Figure 19. Gate 11's window lies in the terminal hold, where horizontal motion is small and the remaining variation is mostly vertical.